কালীবাড়ি খবর

KALIBARI NEWS

(Registered Charity 1158269)
Visit us at: www.londonkalibari.org.uk

Kalibari Centre: 18 Byron Road, Wealdstone, Harrow, HA3 7ST
Issue 20, October 2018

From the Trustee Chairman

Dear Kalibari members and friends
Welcome to the special Puja edition of the Newsletter. We send you all greetings for Bijoya. In this edition we have made space for two items, an article on Mahalaya and Durga Puja, and a poem on Shyama Ma. So some information appears on different pages and the Newslettter looks a bit different.

One piece of good news: we have just signed an extension of the lease for three years, which will allow us to stay in our current location until 28 September 2021. In spite of much effort by our Treasurer in the negotiations, the landlord has increased the monthly rent by £100 (slightly less than first proposed).

For your information:
London Kalibari Trustees are:
Dr Sudin Mandal (Chair), Mrs Jayati Das (Secretary), Mr Mrinal Choudhury (Treasurer), Mrs Krishna Ghosh, Mrs Debjani Sengupta and Dr Satya Chatterjee

Core Support Group:
Mrs Rama Choudhury, Mrs Gita Dutta, Mr Ajit Ghosh, Mrs Babli Mazumdar, Mr Kanu Roy, Mr Snehangshu Basu, Mrs Giti Ray and Mrs Dipti Chatterjee

Donations to the Building Fund: Please make cheques payable to London Kalibari and send them to 13 Kenton Gardens, Harrow, Middlesex, HA3 8DE. For donations by Standing Orders, please contact Mrinal Choudhury.

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General Secretary's Report:
I am pleased to report the renewal of London Kalibari lease for another three years. One devotee has generously donated £500 to replace the carpet of the inner sanctum.

LKB AGM was held on 22 July at Kalibari Centre and we had a good attendance. I would also like to thank Giti Roy for making the Mother Kali's room spectacularly appropriate. Must acknowledge the effort and devotion of Gita Dutta, Avishek Chaudhuri, Kanu Roy , Rama Choudhury and Amiya Bhattacharjee, Joanna Mandal and Dipti Chatterjee and thanks to our Auditor Tanuka Saha , who like her late father audits our accounts free of charge.

We are evermore looking for a suitable property. Let us hope and pray that dream comes a reality soon.
Jai Ma Kali

Treasurer's Statement:
a) Income & Expenditure: (regular per month)

Income –	Standing Order	£255
	Lunch'n Club	£95*
	Donations	£30
	Hall Hire	£40
	Utsav/Events	£100
	Total	£520
Expenditure -	Rent	£600
	Utilities	£85
	Council Tax	£30 (Govt. Relief)
	Total	£715
Shortfall **		£195

* In the Luncheon club (every Monday), one member in turn donates the food and all contributions (nominally £3/head) from other members go to the fund
** Large donations make up the shortfall and leave a surplus for the Building Fund

b) We have a Building Fund. Please ask one of the Trustees if you wish to have further information.

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Cultural Secretary's Report

This Special Edition of our Kalibari Newsletter coincides with Durga Pujo and Kali Pujo. Two most revered celebrations for Bengalese all over the world. Goddess worship is one of the longest standing religious traditions in Hinduism.

"The love between the Divine Mother and her human children is a unique relationship. Kali, the Dark Mother, is one such deity with whom devotees have a very loving and intimate bond, in spite of her fearful appearance. In this relationship, the worshipper becomes a child and Kali assumes the form of the ever-caring mother."

Our intention to carry forward our beliefs and practices, has motivated us to establish London Kalibari. We continue to raise funds by meeting every Monday, thereby to see friends, discuss current issues and share a meal together. We invite speakers and host social events, Annually, we conduct a number of Narayan Pujos and Kali Pujos. We desperately need members, volunteers and supporters to help our cause.

Forthcoming Events 2018/19

- Bijoya Dashami celebration - late November (date to be confirmed)
- Christmas Party - late December (date to be confirmed)
- Narayan Pujo - late March.

Please come and support us. Let us together transform our dream to reality.
JAI Ma

London Kalibari wishes to thank the following:

1. Supporters and helpers from the Community.
2. Harrow Council for Accommodation and Rate Support.
3. Harrow Art Centre for Diwali/Kalipuja.
4. Mr Navin Shah, GLA Member, Wealdstone Labour Hall, for arranging the rental of the Kalibari Centre.
5. Mr Gareth Thomas, MP for Harrow West, Labour Party for his support.
6. Councillors of Harrow Council for their support and encouragement.
7. Sponsors of Kalibari events & activities.
8. Ms Tanuka Saha, of N. Saha & Co. Chartered Accountants.
9. Mr Avishek Chaudhuri for website.

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Divine Opera, Autumnal Hymn

By Radha Biswas , October 2018

(an abridged form of an article published by The Times of India)

There was a voice on the radio in my childhood. It came on only once a year, usually on a nippy October morning around 4.00.

In the still dark hours, my mother and I would huddle in front of an old Murphy radio in the living room in Northern Town where I grew up, wrapped in a light shawl. Ma would fiddle with the knob until the static gave way to music; then the voice would come on. I would be half asleep still, and understood little of the Sanskrit I heard, but the chants, interspersed with songs, cast a spell, as the story of Ma Durga unfolded, and my Ma translated in bits when the recitation stopped, and the music began.

It was the divine opera of Mahalaya, the harbinger of the autumnal Durga Puja for Bengalis everywhere. And through this opera, the voice told the story of Ma Durga's descent to earth after vanquishing the demon king, Mahishashura. Ma translated it into simple Bangla for me, in soft whispers, as if afraid to disturb a live performance, of how and why the gods created Durga to save earth and heavens from conquest by the demon king. And how she succeeded, where every god and mortal had failed, becoming *Mahishashuramardini*.

I remember the opera beginning with the sound of a conch shell, breaking the silence of pre-dawn, a chorus rising, then the voice coming into its own. At first, a slow incantation building up, a prayer, an invocation, the voice rising tremulously as if trying to reach the heavens. The story going on to describe the gods creating and arming the goddess, turning her into *Dashapraharanadharini* (the ten-weaponed one); the incantations invoking every Divine Feminine form through the Chandi Paath, "Ya Devi Sarva Bhuteshu...". The Gods beseeching Durga to awaken and rise, "Jaago tumi jaago", as the fate of the universe hung in the balance. The chants ever more rousing, the chorus of accompanying singers falling, rising, until the crescendo of cymbal clashes and conch shells sounded

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(continued from page 4)

out Durga's victory as she finally vanquished the demon with her trident. I would try to imagine the scenes as she went along, with the previous year's idols in mind.

Then the voice again, dropping, weeping with joy and relief. Then, silence. Finally, the sweet melodious chorus, "Rupam Dehi, Jayan Dehi, Yasho Dehi...", hailing her victory and bidding her good bye, as it came time for her departure from her heavenly abode at her husband's house in Kailash, for her annual visit to her parent's home here on earth, with her children, for the four days of festivities that we celebrate as Durga Puja. Morning would break, and Ma would be happily humming Rupam Dehi... as she went about her chores with her duster tucked at her waist...

That particular voice, as I found out much later, belonged to the Bengali radio artiste and playwright, Birendra Krishna Bhadra, and that this was a legendary radio program that was unparalleled in Indian radio history. His invocation was so powerful, so steeped in devotion as he swept you along, that it was hard to believe this was acting. First aired in 1931, this entire composition was performed live by a company of actors, singers and a live orchestra for more than 30 years. Legend has it that the artistes treated their performance as no less sacred than the Puja itself, bathing and purifying themselves before the performance, donning new clothes, as they would for any sacred ritual. No wonder then, their offering was so sublime!

Sometime in the 1960s it became a taped event, broadcast before dawn. Many subsequent versions were aired over the years, but his voice, to me, and for millions of Bengalis, was irreplaceable. Ma carried it on a cassette when we moved abroad, and later, I carried it around during my years in the USA. Today, one can watch an enactment of Mahalaya on TV in the early morning. But I prefer to stick to that original radio version, mercifully aired by FM stations in Calcutta, and now available on Youtube.

Since coming back to India from Boston six years ago, whenever I could, I tried to follow the Mahalaya morning ritual in Calcutta with my mother. Heading to her room just before dawn, I would switch on her little FM radio. Sometimes my

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daughter would be with me. As I tried to get the station airing the Krishna Bhadra recording, Ma would stir awake, even in these last years where multiple medications for her many ailments made her disoriented

She would sit up slowly, calling out to her attendants, Deepti and Parvati, sleeping nearby. I would hear the radios and TVs coming alive in different corners of the apartment building. And then that familiar voice would come on. Together, Ma, her attendants, and I, would gather ourselves, and over the next two hours, half dozing, we would allow the chants and music to take us above the clouds, listening, until morning broke.

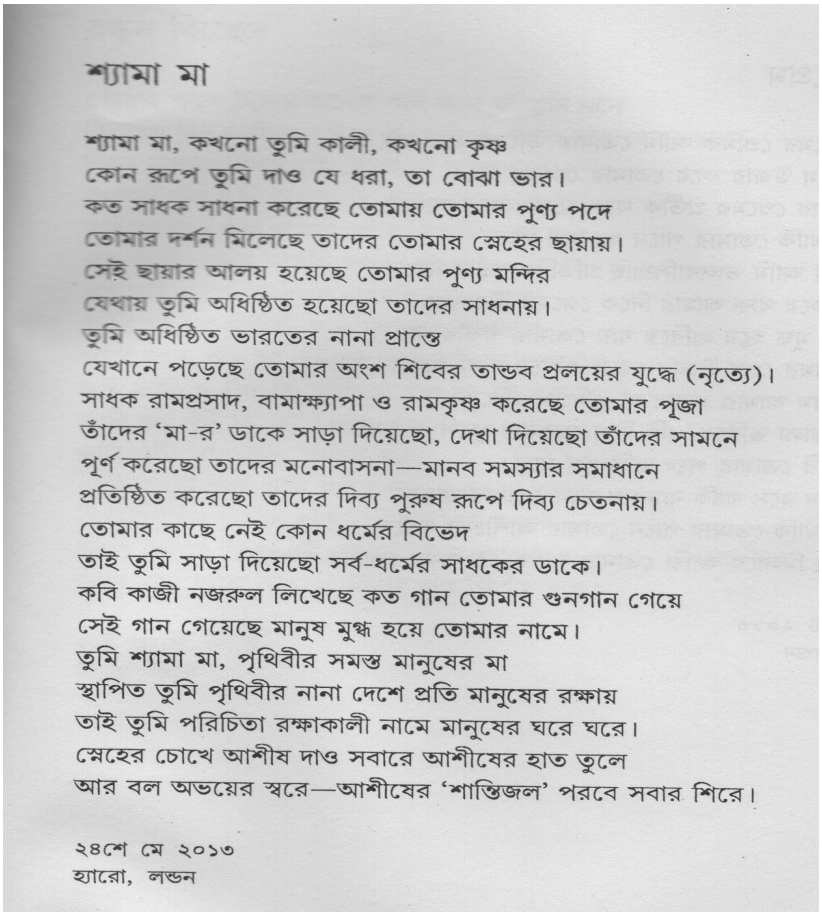
In these last three years since moving back to Jamshedpur, I spent every Durga Puja with Ma in Kolkata. Her involvement, and gradually her awareness of the festivities, diminished as she succumbed to dementia. But she would participate sporadically, especially when I brought home the Puja shopping.

The apartment building in which she lived, held, and holds still, a Durga Puja on the terrace every year. From the evening of Panchami when the thunder of dhaaks would signal the arrival of the Devi in our building, Ma would be in a happy place, asking for the door to be always left open. Throughout the four days of the Pujas, the periodic call of the shankha - the conch shell and the dhaaks, would rouse her from increasingly frequent day time naps on her wheelchair.

I lost Ma this summer as she succumbed to a virulent infection of the lungs. She was 81. This is the first time when I won't be heading to Kolkata to be with her. As the Puja draws closer, I find myself suspended in memories like the one of Mahalaya, and increasingly, memories of my Ma singing. Like autumn leaves, the memories keep falling, wafting down around me.

The usual signs of Durga Puja are coming to life, the dew and Shiuli blossoms on the grass, the cooler nights signalling the change of season, the sun's rise in the southern skies, the pandals mushrooming to life in the neighbourhood. Soon the first beats of the dhaaks will be welcoming the Devi home in all her resplendent glory. And in the sounds, songs and scents of this season, yours is the voice I will be holding on to, Ma.

Mother Kali - A poem by Mrinal Choudhury



শ্যামা মা

শ্যামা মা, কখনো তুমি কালী, কখনো কৃষ্ণ
কোন রূপে তুমি দাও যে ধরা, তা বোঝা ভার।
কত সাধক সাধনা করেছে তোমায় তোমার পুণ্য পদে
তোমার দর্শন মিলেছে তাদের তোমার স্নেহের ছায়ায়।
সেই ছায়ার আলয় হয়েছে তোমার পুণ্য মন্দির
যেথায় তুমি অধিষ্ঠিত হয়েছো তাদের সাধনায়।
তুমি অধিষ্ঠিত ভারতের নানা প্রান্তে
যেখানে পড়েছে তোমার অংশ শিবের তান্ডব প্রলয়ের যুদ্ধে (নৃত্যে)।
সাধক রামপ্রসাদ, বামাক্ষ্যাপা ও রামকৃষ্ণ করেছে তোমার পূজা
তাঁদের 'মা-র' ডাকে সাড়া দিয়েছো, দেখা দিয়েছো তাঁদের সামনে
পূর্ণ করেছো তাদের মনোবাসনা—মানব সমস্যার সমাধানে
প্রতিষ্ঠিত করেছো তাদের দিব্য পুরুষ রূপে দিব্য চেতনায়।
তোমার কাছে নেই কোন ধর্মের বিভেদ
তাই তুমি সাড়া দিয়েছো সর্ব-ধর্মের সাধকের ডাকে।
কবি কাজী নজরুল লিখেছে কত গান তোমার গুনগান গেয়ে
সেই গান গেয়েছে মানুষ মুগ্ধ হয়ে তোমার নামে।
তুমি শ্যামা মা, পৃথিবীর সমস্ত মানুষের মা
স্থাপিত তুমি পৃথিবীর নানা দেশে প্রতি মানুষের রক্ষায়
তাই তুমি পরিচিতা রক্ষাকালী নামে মানুষের ঘরে ঘরে।
স্নেহের চোখে আশীষ দাও সবারে আশীষের হাত তুলে
আর বল অভয়ের স্বরে—আশীষের 'শান্তিজল' পরবে সবার শিরে।

২৪শে মে ২০১৩
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Community Corner

Swami Vivekananda Statue In Harrow (Progress).

The Model of Swamiji Statue has been sent by ship from Kolkata on 14 October 2018. Hopefully arriving at Felixstowe port in middle of November 2018. Soon afterwards it will be transported to the studio of Tom Nicholls, the sculptor. He will use the model to make the final statue in Portland Stone. If everything goes well in terms of fundraising and work schedule, we should be able to unveil the statue in early July 2019 (note: 4th July is Swamiji's Mahaprayan day).
For donations please contact Mrinal Choudhury - 0208907 5946 or 07803083106

London Kalibari Community Centre Project

London Kalibari is an organisation representing the Hindu Bengalee Community in the UK. It is a charity registered in 1982 and converted into a Charitable Incorporated Organisation (CIO) in 2014. It has raised funds for the Community Centre Project through many social and cultural activities.

Our aim is to establish a permanent Community Centre in which social, cultural and spiritual activities can be held regularly. In the meantime, we have acquired a leased accommodation at **18 Byron Road, Harrow, Wealdstone, HA3 7ST**, with a main hall, two smaller rooms, kitchen and two toilets. The Centre is used for social and religious activities including a Luncheon Club on Mondays between 1pm and 4pm. A suitable larger property is estimated to cost around £1Million. A smaller property of the sort we are currently using will cost up to £500,000 with suitable alterations. We are looking to purchase the current site but no offer of sale has yet been made – we are continuing to pursue this. If we were to move to a different site, the main problem is to get permission to hold large community activities. Also, significant monies will have to be raised from the community. London Kalibari has a Building Fund and many members have donated £1,000 each and much larger pledges have also been made. We hope you can support us in this worthy cause.

Please note: Our intention is that when we have acquired a permanent centre, all contributions will be acknowledged, and those contributing significant amounts will be specially named (such as on a board or on a plaque).

Contacts:

Sudin	Jayati	Mrinal
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